distance of about 200 kilometres, and launched our operation. We were able to apprehend a few insurgents, while a majority of them escaped into Myanmar without putting up a fight. We destroyed the camp and returned to our base. The brigade commander, Brigadier V.R. Raghavan, a clear-headed, mature, soft-spoken professional and a man of few words, conveyed in a letter to me that 'the execution of the operation by the battalion was like clockwork'. A 'clasp' to the general service medal was instituted for all ranks who participated in this operation. Besides this, Major P.S. Bhandral of our battalion was given a gallantry award, the Sena Medal. Havildar Vinayak Thosar (now an officer) and a few other ranks received the commendations of the chief of army staff, and I was decorated with the Vishisht Seva Medal (distinguished services medal). The battalion returned to Tezu and resumed its usual activities – operational recces and discussions, professional and sports events and routine administration. The other battalion, 9 Dogra, which was given a similar mission as us, did equally well but had one or two casualties. We were fortunate to have had no mishap.

In February 1982, the mother of all sand model discussions took place at the Division HQ located in Dinjan. This was on the concept of mobile defence in the mountains. The brainchild of the GOC, Major General Misbah Mayadas, the subject evoked a lot of interest amongst all officers, particularly the brass. Most of them, including Lieutenant General A.S. Vaidya, MVC and bar, the GOC-in-C of Eastern Command and downwards, were present during the deliberations. There were three or four syndicates formed. Each of them was led by a brigade commander with three members, who were handpicked battalion or regiment commanders. Unfortunately, the discussions ran into heavy weather on day one itself! Our syndicate was led by my brigade commander, Brigadier Ved Prakash Airy, MVC, also a highly decorated war veteran. He was a frank and outspoken officer, and I was one of his battalion commanders.

The preliminaries were over, and the new concept was being described to us when Brigadier Airy got up and remarked that he